

SOLAR ENERGY TO OUR RESCUE

Solar power is bang in the middle of a take-off in India right now. Several new companies from India and abroad have begun their solar operations in India and existing companies have committed to expanding their capacity



■ UMA BANSAL

With abundant sunlight, India offers a unique opportunity for development of solar photovoltaic (PV) power both for domestic consumption and export. Developing the solar PV market will not only ensure energy independence of the country but also help reduce

greenhouse gas emissions.

Thanks to the Jawaharlal Nehru National Solar Mission (JNNSM) launched by the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy and Ministry of Power in January last year, solar PV power is bang in the middle of a take-off in India right now.

The JNNSM targets 22 GW of installed solar generation capac-

ity by 2022, 100 GW by 2030 and 200 GW by 2050. It aims to achieve grid parity by 2022 and parity with thermal-based generation by 2030. It also aims to install 4-5 GW of solar manufacturing capacity in India by 2017.

India is all set to not only meet but beat the target of National Solar Mission. In the near term, the solar industry is looking to reach the total installed base of about 1 GW. Over the next two to three years, it may achieve 1-1.5 GW of annual installations year-on-year.

"More than 300 MW of solar PV projects are currently under execution. Another 500 MW of solar thermal projects are also under execution under the JNNSM. In addition to this, more than 900 MW of solar projects, both PV and thermal, have been signed up and are under execution in Gujarat," informs K. Subramanya, chief executive officer, Tata BP Solar.

Several new companies from India and abroad have begun their solar operations in India and existing companies have committed to expanding their capacity. States like Gujarat and Rajasthan have announced their own solar policies, providing further impetus to the solar industry. Off-grid applications, which are highly relevant to rural India, are also receiving due attention.